Like Eisenhower, Kennedy hoped that India would alleviate its China problem by settling its Pakistan one. But Kennedy and Johnson resisted Ayub's calls for the US to leverage its economic assistance or the Indian need for US support vis-à-vis its China challenge to push India toward a Kashmir solution. Kennedy did promise to discuss the possibility of an India-Pakistan settlement with Indian officials.[195]

The Sino-Indian border situation, as Galbraith explained, along with upcoming elections in India in February 1962, actually limited how far Nehru could go.[196] Nehru reiterated to Kennedy that he was willing to accept the status quo in Kashmir with some minor changes if necessary.[197] The US subsequently urged him to take some visible action to stop Pakistan from bringing Kashmir up at the UN, which would make things difficult for everyone. He refused Kennedy's offer of a mediator, but agreed to try to sit down with Ayub and subsequently invited him to India.[198]

Rawalpindi, nonetheless, brought the issue to the UN, which led to consternation in India and more American frustration with Pakistan. The US refused to sponsor the UN resolution but felt it had to support it.[199] In parliament Nehru expressed his disappointment with the US and UK, noting that on Kashmir and Goa the two countries would "almost invariably be against us." Rusk told Galbraith that the remarks had irritated Congress and the president, especially since the US had worked to moderate the resolution.[200] Administration officials were, however, none too pleased with Pakistan either, resenting that it pushed the US to take a public stand at the UN.

Pakistan's developing relationship with China had also upset the administration. In 1959, intelligence analysts had dismissed the idea that Sino-Pakistani ties would expand.[201] During the Kennedy administration, however, the Pakistani government appeared to move toward a more neutral position, pursuing economic engagement with Moscow and border talks with Beijing. In 1959, Ayub had publicly stated that Pakistan would not accept any Sino-Indian agreement that covered their western boundary because that area was in Jammu and Kashmir.[202] By spring 1961, he was telling the American ambassador that Pakistan should itself reach a border agreement with Beijing. The Pakistani finance minister told Kennedy that China had approached Pakistan for a settlement, probably because it would give them an advantage in negotiations with India.[203] Just two weeks later